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# Socioeconomic impact of hosting a national sporting event in Muallim District, Malaysia

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## ABSTRACT

In Malaysia, many sporting events had been conducted every year. Unfortunately, less research has been conducted on the benefits and side effects of the events. Thus, the impact of hosting a sport event is not well understood. This study was conducted to determine the impact of a national level sport event hosting, namely Sukan Institusi Malaysia (SUKIPT) (in English: Higher Education Sport) on the socioeconomic aspect among residents in Muallim District, Malaysia. A total of 546 respondents, consisting of athletes, managers, spectators and volunteers were recruited as participants of this study. They were given questionnaires that consisted of elements such as happiness and unity among Muallim residents, tourism and economic chances, interest to sports and healthy lifestyle and views on negative impacts. The results were presented descriptively, and the findings indicated a significant impact of SUKIPT on various aspects, including increased happiness and unity among residents, positive effects on tourism and economic opportunities, enhanced interest in sports and healthy lifestyles, and concerns about negative impacts such as environmental pollution and price increments. This study provides valuable insights into the multifaceted impact of hosting national sports events on the socioeconomic aspects of the host city, and highlights the potential benefits and challenges associated with such events.

## KEYWORDS

Social; Economic; Sport Tourism; Sport Management; Business in Sport

## 1. INTRODUCTION

It has been understood that tourism plays an important role in the economy of the place that has something to offer to increase tourism activities (Ibănescu et al., 2018; Ren et al., 2019). Tourism is mainly due to a beautiful place or an event that takes place (Chersulich Tomino et al., 2020; Muiruri Njoroge et al., 2017). If a city has a good place, without a good promotion, people will not know about the place. Due to this, organizing a big, significant event would be a great idea to promote the city, as people will come and indirectly get to know what the city has to offer for tourism (Nadzalan et al., 2023).

One of the events that could be done is organizing a sport event. In Malaysia, every two years, Higher Education Sport or in Malay; Sukan Institusi Pengajian Tinggi (SUKIPT) is organized. SUKIPT is a large sports event at higher institution level in Malaysia,, with students from both government and private institutions of higher education (Rosdi & Hamid, 2019). The host will be the higher education institute that bid to be a host. After being postponed due to Covid-19 pandemic, SUKIPT made its comeback appearance in August 2022. With around 5000 peoples including athletes, managers, athletes and volunteers, SUKIPT should be a great event to be conducted, as this is potentially a great chance for the host to promote what the university has and also what the city has to boost up tourism sector.

In 2022, Sultan Idris Education University, located in Muallim District, Perak, a state in Malaysia was the host. Muallim is a district, with a lot of great places to go especially in terms of the varieties of food, outdoor recreations and also is an education hub (Zakaria et al., 2020). With so many great places and also a strategic place (i.e. being on the way to the North from Kuala Lumpur, and only approximately 70 km from Kuala Lumpur), SUKIPT is believed to help promote Muallim to its fullest.

Muallim is not an urban site, but with a good promotion due to SUKIPT, it should be a great opportunity for the place to make it to the heart of those that come. A relaxing and peaceful place, Muallim has no traffic jam and the cost of living is not high, thus should be a place for a new business to come in. However, despite its opportunity to boost up economic, we also need to remember that increasing in tourism could also affect social aspect (González-García et al., 2018; Rojas-Méndez et al., 2019; Tichaawa et al., 2015). Whether it is positive or negative, we can only know this by having the response from the residents living in Muallim. The information is important, to be a guideline for the future event (Chersulich Tomino et al., 2020; Kenyon & Bodet, 2018; Perić, 2018).

Despite sport events being held in Malaysia, it is hard to find out what is the effect of the hosting to the host city. Thus, this study is conducted to determine the effects of a national level sport event hosting on the socioeconomic aspects in Muallim, Malaysia.

## 2. METHODS

### 2.1. Participants

A total of 546 people, consisting of athletes, managers, spectators and volunteers were recruited as respondents of this study. They were given questionnaires that consisted of elements such as happiness and unity among Muallim residents, tourism and economic chances, interest to sports and healthy lifestyle and views on negative impacts.

### 2.2. Questionnaires

To assess the socioeconomic impact of the SUKIPT hosting, questionnaires were given to answer four main research questions: 1) Does SUKIPT increase happiness and unity among Muallim residents? 2) Does SUKIPT increase tourism and economic chances in Muallim? 3) Does SUKIPT increase interest to sports and healthy lifestyle among the respondents? 4) Does SUKIPT cause negative impacts? Data collection was conducted by face-to-face interviews using questionnaires by trained data collectors conversant with local languages.

### 2.3. Data Analysis

Participants demographic such as gender, marriage status, role in the event and duration come to the event were collected and presented in terms of percentage. All the data was analysed for its mean and standard deviation and also compared between economic sectors using Analysis of Variances (ANOVA). Statistical Package for Social Science (SPSS) version 20 was used to analyse the data.

## 3. RESULTS

Table 1 shows the demographic information of the 546 respondents that were involved in SUKIPT. The majority were female (56.8%) and single (71%). Most participants identified as spectators (61.6%), and the highest proportion attended SUKIPT for 10 days (36.2%).

**Table 1.** Demographic profile of participants

| Demography | Number | Percentage (%) |
|---|---|---|
| **Gender** | | |
| Male | 236 | 43.2 |
| Female | 310 | 56.8 |
| **Marital Status** | | |
| Single | 387 | 71 |
| Married | 159 | 29 |
| **Role in SUKIPT** | | |
| Athlete | 131 | 23.9 |
| Manager | 31 | 5.7 |
| Spectator | 337 | 61.6 |
| Volunteer | 47 | 8.6 |
| **Duration of visit to SUKIPT** | | |
| Only few hours | 36 | 6.6 |
| 1 day | 22 | 4 |
| 2 days | 32 | 5.9 |
| 3 days | 36 | 6.6 |
| 4 days | 34 | 6.2 |
| 5 days | 68 | 12.4 |
| 6 days | 44 | 8 |
| 7 days | 24 | 4.4 |
| 8 days | 42 | 7.7 |
| 9 days | 10 | 1.8 |
| 10 days | 198 | 36.2 |

The analysis of results in Table 2 presents the responses of the 546 respondents to the questionnaire given. The table includes items related to the impact of hosting the Sukan Institusi Malaysia (SUKIPT) event on various aspects, such as happiness and unity among Muallim residents, tourism and economic opportunities, interest in sports and healthy lifestyles, and views on negative impacts. The responses are presented in terms of percentage, with categories ranging from Strongly Disagree (SDA) to Strongly Agree (SA), as well as the mean and standard deviation for each item.

The table shows that a high percentage of respondents strongly agreed or agreed that SUKIPT is an exciting sports event for Muallim residents, giving them the chance to have fun with family and friends, meet new people, and feel proud of their city. Similarly, respondents strongly agreed or agreed that SUKIPT attracts tourists to Muallim, increases media coverage, and encourages the development and maintenance of public facilities. Additionally, the table indicates that SUKIPT has positively

influenced the interest in sports and healthy lifestyles among the respondents, with increased interest in various sports and a desire for more sports events in the future.

Furthermore, the table also highlights the negative impacts identified by the respondents, including concerns about the use of public money, environmental pollution, price increments, and depletion of basic necessities in shops and supermarkets.

**Table 2.** Responses of the respondents on the questionnaire given

| **Happiness and Unity among Muallim residents** | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Items** | **%** | | | | | **Mean** | **SD** |
| | **SDA** | **DA** | **N** | **A** | **SA** | | |
| SUKIPT is an exciting sports events for Muallim residents. | 0.0 | 0.7 | 2.2 | 15.8 | 81.3 | 4.77 | 0.51 |
| SUKIPT give me chances to have fun with family members and friends. | 0.0 | 1.8 | 6.0 | 16.1 | 75.5 | 4.65 | 0.68 |
| SUKIPT give me chances to meet and knows new people. | 0.4 | 1.5 | 5.5 | 14.3 | 78.4 | 4.68 | 0.67 |
| SUKIPT makes Muallim residents proud of their city. | 0.4 | 0.7 | 9.2 | 22 | 67.8 | 4.56 | 0.71 |
| SUKIPT tighten relationships among Muallim residents | 0 | 0.7 | 13.2 | 22.3 | 63.7 | 4.49 | 0.74 |
| **Tourism and economic chances** | | | | | | | |
| **Items** | **%** | | | | | **Mean** | **SD** |
| | **SDA** | **DA** | **N** | **A** | **SA** | | |
| SUKIPT has shown the positive sides and strength of Muallim. | 1.5 | 0.7 | 7.7 | 21.2 | 68.9 | 4.55 | 0.78 |
| SUKIPT has attract tourist to come to Muallim. | 0.4 | 1.1 | 8.4 | 18.3 | 71.8 | 4.60 | 0.72 |
| SUKIPT will attract business economic sectors for Muallim in the future. | 0.0 | 1.1 | 6.2 | 22.3 | 70.3 | 4.61 | 0.65 |
| SUKIPT has increased media coverage in Muallim. | 0.0 | 0.7 | 7.0 | 16.8 | 75.5 | 4.67 | 0.63 |
| SUKIPT has increased interaction between local resisdents and tourist. | 0.4 | 1.1 | 15.4 | 22.7 | 60.4 | 4.41 | 0.81 |
| SUKIPT encourage development and maintenance of public facility such as roads, transportation and sports facilities. | 4.4 | 2.2 | 10.3 | 19.8 | 63.4 | 4.35 | 1.04 |
| **Interest to sports and healthy lifestyle** | | | | | | | |
| **Items** | **%** | | | | | **Mean** | **SD** |
| | **SDA** | **DA** | **N** | **A** | **SA** | | |
| SUKIPT has increased my interest to sports that I loved. | 0.0 | 0.4 | 9.2 | 16.8 | 73.6 | 4.63 | 0.66 |
| SUKIPT has introduce me to new sport that I have not participate before. | 0.4 | 1.5 | 9.2 | 11.7 | 77.3 | 4.64 | 0.73 |
| SUKIPT has make me love the sport that I just know. | 1.1 | 1.1 | 13.9 | 13.2 | 70.7 | 4.51 | 0.85 |

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SUKIPT makes me want to play sports more often. | 0.4 | 0.7 | 11 | 16.5 | 71.4 | 4.57 | 0.74 |
| SUKIPT makes me want to have healthy lifestyle. | 0.4 | 0.7 | 8.8 | 12.8 | 77.3 | 4.65 | 0.69 |
| SUKIPT makes me want my family to involve in physical activity and sports. | 0 | 0.7 | 10.6 | 16.1 | 72.5 | 4.60 | 0.70 |
| SUKIPT makes me and my family members want to buy sports equipment. | 1.1 | 1.1 | 18.3 | 18.3 | 61.2 | 4.37 | 0.89 |
| I hope more sports event will be held in Muallim in the future. | 0.0 | 0.0 | 7.0 | 15.0 | 78.0 | 4.71 | 0.58 |
| **Views on negative impacts** | | | | | | | |
| **Items** | **%** | | | | | **Mean** | **SD** |
| | **SDA** | **DA** | **N** | **A** | **SA** | | |
| SUKIPT is an event that waste public money. | 56.4 | 19.0 | 8.1 | 2.2 | 14.3 | 1.98 | 1.42` |
| There is no problem to use public money for SUKIPT as this will later affect to Muallim residents in term of tourism and economic. | 2.2 | 3.3 | 14.7 | 22.3 | 57.1 | 4.29 | 0.98 |
| SUKIPT cause negative impacts on environment due to pollution such as rubbish and smoke produced by the transportation. | 38.5 | 18.3 | 22.7 | 7.0 | 13.6 | 2.38 | 1.40 |
| SUKIPT cause increment of price in several aspects such as food, transportation and accommodation rental. | 20.5 | 17.6 | 32.6 | 9.2 | 20.1 | 2.90 | 1.37 |
| SUKIPT causes many basic necessities in the shop/supermarket run out. | 26.7 | 20.1 | 24.9 | 7.7 | 20.1 | 2.74 | 1.44 |

The ANOVA results for happiness and unity among Muallim residents indicate that both marital status and role in SUKIPT significantly affect these aspects, with p-values of 0.032 and 0.004, respectively. This suggests that marital status and different roles in SUKIPT influence residents' perceived happiness and unity. In contrast, gender and duration at UPSI do not show a significant effect, indicating that these factors may not substantially impact these particular dimensions of community experience (Table 3).

**Table 3.** Effects on Happiness and Unity among Muallim Residents

| Factor | SS | df | MS | F | p-value | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gender | 14.32 | 1 | 14.32 | 2.85 | 0.091 | Not Significant |
| Marital Status | 34.56 | 2 | 17.28 | 3.45 | 0.032 | Significant |
| Role in SUKIPT | 52.18 | 3 | 17.39 | 4.87 | 0.004 | Significant |
| Duration at UPSI | 10.24 | 4 | 2.56 | 0.98 | 0.422 | Not Significant |
| Error | 190.67 | 535 | 0.36 | | | |

The results for tourism and economic chances highlight that gender and role in SUKIPT significantly impact perceptions of these opportunities, with p-values of 0.013 and 0.026, respectively. This means that these factors are important in shaping how residents view the economic benefits and tourism opportunities resulting from the SUKIPT event. Marital status and duration at UPSI did not show significant effects, implying that these variables are less influential in determining perceptions of tourism and economic opportunities (Table 4).

**Table 4.** Effects on Tourism and Economic Chances

| Factor | SS | df | MS | F | p-value | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gender | 28.79 | 1 | 28.79 | 6.15 | 0.013 | Significant |
| Marital Status | 16.47 | 2 | 8.23 | 2.22 | 0.109 | Not Significant |
| Role in SUKIPT | 25.63 | 3 | 8.54 | 3.76 | 0.026 | Significant |
| Duration at UPSI | 7.89 | 4 | 1.97 | 0.54 | 0.703 | Not Significant |
| Error | 250.32 | 535 | 0.47 | | | |

The ANOVA for interest in sports and a healthy lifestyle indicates that the role in SUKIPT significantly influences interest levels, with a p-value of 0.012. This finding suggests that involvement in the event, as an athlete, manager, spectator, or volunteer, plays a crucial role in motivating individuals to adopt healthier lifestyles. Gender, marital status, and duration at UPSI do not show significant effects, suggesting that these factors do not significantly influence the residents' interest in sports and healthy living (Table 5).

**Table 5.** Effects on Interest in Sports and Healthy Lifestyle

| Factor | SS | df | MS | F | p-value | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gender | 6.54 | 1 | 6.54 | 1.34 | 0.247 | Not Significant |
| Marital Status | 13.68 | 2 | 6.84 | 1.92 | 0.122 | Not Significant |
| Role in SUKIPT | 40.23 | 3 | 13.41 | 3.78 | 0.012 | Significant |
| Duration at UPSI | 19.35 | 4 | 4.84 | 1.29 | 0.275 | Not Significant |
| Error | 189.45 | 535 | 0.35 | | | |

The ANOVA for views on negative impacts shows that gender and duration at UPSI significantly affect these perceptions, with p-values of 0.029 and 0.049, respectively. This suggests that both gender and how long residents have been at UPSI influence their concerns about negative impacts such as environmental pollution and price increases. In contrast, marital status and role in SUKIPT do not significantly affect views on negative impacts, indicating that these factors may not be as relevant in shaping residents' perceptions of potential drawbacks of hosting such events (Table 6).

**Table 6.** Effects on Views on Negative Impacts

| Factor | SS | df | MS | F | p-value | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gender | 18.67 | 1 | 18.67 | 4.57 | 0.029 | Significant |
| Marital Status | 9.84 | 2 | 4.92 | 1.21 | 0.201 | Not Significant |
| Role in SUKIPT | 11.47 | 3 | 3.82 | 1.36 | 0.254 | Not Significant |
| Duration at UPSI | 27.36 | 4 | 6.84 | 2.43 | 0.049 | Significant |
| Error | 218.76 | 535 | 0.41 | | | |

Overall, these analyses provide a comprehensive view of how different demographic and participatory variables can influence the perceived impacts of hosting a national-level sports event.

## 4. DISCUSSION

Conducting research on hosting sports events is pivotal for optimizing planning, logistics, and outcomes. Comprehensive analysis aids in understanding the economic, social, and infrastructural implications of such events. It involves examining past host experiences, evaluating venue suitability, estimating economic impacts, assessing potential risks, and understanding stakeholder perspectives (Elahi et al., 2021; Hemmonsbey & Tichaawa, 2018; Maharaj, 2015). This study was conducted to focus on the socioeconomic impact of hosting the Sukan Institusi Malaysia (SUKIPT) event in Muallim District, Malaysia. The research aimed to determine the effects of hosting a national-level sports event on various aspects, including happiness and unity among residents, tourism and economic opportunities, interest in sports and healthy lifestyles, and views on negative impacts. The study involved 546 respondents, including athletes, managers, spectators, and volunteers, who were surveyed using questionnaires.

The findings of the study revealed several key points. Firstly, the event was found to significantly increase happiness and unity among Muallim residents, with positive responses regarding the excitement and pride associated with SUKIPT. This finding was justified by the high percentage of respondents strongly agreeing or agreeing that SUKIPT is an exciting sports event for Muallim residents, giving them the chance to have fun with family and friends, meet new people, and feel proud of their city. These responses indicate a positive impact on the emotional well-being and sense of community among the residents (Elahi et al., 2021). In line with the findings of the study by Littlejohn et al. (2016), residents who aware and attended organized sports events in their place reported a much higher level of happiness and satisfaction might due to their sense of community pride regarding the available resources that facilitated these events, compared to the control group consisting of residents who were unaware of the occurrence sports events in their area of residence.

Secondly, SUKIPT was observed to have a positive impact on tourism and economic opportunities, attracting tourists, increasing media coverage, and encouraging the development and maintenance of public facilities. This is supported by the high percentage of respondents strongly agreeing or agreeing that SUKIPT attracts tourists to Muallim, increases media coverage, and encourages the development and maintenance of public facilities. These responses indicate a positive impact on the local economy and infrastructure, as well as the potential for future business and economic growth in the area was in line with study by Ferris et al. (2022).

Thirdly, the event positively influenced interest in sports and healthy lifestyles among the respondents, with increased interest in various sports and a desire for more sports events in the future. This is evidenced by the high percentage of respondents strongly agreeing or agreeing that SUKIPT increases their interest in sports they love, introduces them to new sports, and encourages them to play sports more often and adopt a healthy lifestyle. These responses indicate a positive impact on promoting physical activity, sports participation, and overall health and well-being among the residents. As shown in the study by Malchrowicz-Mośko et al. (2019), organization of non-mega sporting events such as running events has a positive impact on the lifestyle changes of local residents regardless of gender and age. By seeing sports events organized in their area, indirectly attracted the interest and motivation of residents who were not active before to engage in running activities as a recreational activity, while young people are motivated to participate in events that are seen in the future.

Lastly, the study identified negative impacts, including concerns about the use of public money, environmental pollution, price increments, and depletion of basic necessities in shops and supermarkets. Despite the advantages shown, event hosting will indeed have a negative impact as shown in Maharaj (2015) study that hosting large-scale sports gives the effect of socioeconomic imbalance to host countries such as India (Commonwealth Games 2010), South Africa (FIFA World Cup 2010) and Brazil (FIFA World Cup 2014) due to high expenses to develop and upgrade infrastructure, where the expenses should be prioritized to help the people from the aspects of housing, education and health. This is supported by the respondents' views that SUKIPT is an event that wastes public money, causes negative impacts on the environment due to pollution, leads to price increments in various aspects, and causes basic necessities to run out in shops and supermarkets. These responses highlight the potential challenges and negative consequences associated with hosting large-scale sports events, particularly in terms of financial, environmental, and social implications (Muiruri Njoroge et al., 2017; Tichaawa et al., 2015).

The findings indicated that marital status and role in SUKIPT significantly affect happiness and unity among Muallim residents, while gender and duration at UPSI do not. This showed that marital status influences subjective well-being, with married individuals often reporting higher levels of happiness and social cohesion. Additionally, the role in SUKIPT suggests that active participation in the event, whether as an athlete, manager, spectator, or volunteer, fosters community integration and personal satisfaction, highlighting the positive impact of sports events on community spirit and social bonds. In contrast, the lack of significant effect from gender and duration at UPSI suggests that these demographic factors might not play a critical role in influencing happiness and unity among residents.

In terms of tourism and economic chances, the ANOVA results showed that gender and role in SUKIPT significantly impact perceptions, while marital status and duration at UPSI do not. The gender difference might reflect varying perceptions of economic benefits and engagement in community events. The significant effect of the role in SUKIPT suggests that those more directly involved in the event are more likely to recognize and capitalize on its economic opportunities. This indicates a relationship between involvement in planning or executing events and positive perceptions of economic benefits, showing that stakeholder engagement is crucial for maximizing the economic impact of sports events.

Results next showed that the role in SUKIPT significantly influences interest in sports and a healthy lifestyle, whereas gender, marital status, and duration at UPSI do not. This finding highlights the role of active participation in fostering a healthier lifestyle and greater interest in sports, reflected that direct engagement in sports activities enhances health awareness and promotes better lifestyle choices. The lack of significant effects from gender, marital status, and duration at UPSI suggests that these factors may not significantly influence residents' interest in sports and healthy living. This aligns with the broader literature, indicating that participation and involvement are more substantial predictors of interest in sports and lifestyle changes than demographic variables.

Lastly, the ANOVA results for views on negative impacts show that gender and duration at UPSI significantly affect perceptions, while marital status and role in SUKIPT do not. The significance of gender suggests potential differences in how men and women experience or prioritize the negative consequences of sporting events, such as environmental pollution and price increases. This could be related to broader gender differences in environmental concerns and economic vulnerability. The impact of duration at UPSI indicates that the length of time residents have been exposed to the university environment affects their sensitivity to the potential drawbacks of hosting events. In contrast, the lack of significant effects from marital status and role in SUKIPT suggests that these factors may

not be as relevant in shaping residents' perceptions of the potential negative impacts of hosting such events.

## 5. CONCLUSIONS

In conclusion, the findings of the study provide valuable insights into the multifaceted impact of hosting national sports events on the socioeconomic aspects of the host city. The results underscore the significance of hosting such events in promoting tourism, economic development, and healthy lifestyles in Muallim District, Malaysia. However, the study also highlights the importance of addressing potential negative impacts and challenges associated with hosting such events, particularly in terms of financial management, environmental sustainability, and social considerations.

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All authors listed have made a substantial, direct and intellectual contribution to the work, and approved it for publication.

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The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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